

Human ancestors

Modern humans (*Homo sapiens*) are a type of ape that evolved from a common ape ancestor in Africa, and our closest living relatives today are chimpanzees. Chimp and human ancestors separated more than six million years ago, when one group of apes, called hominins, began to walk upright. Hominins then went on to evolve bigger brains and develop humanlike behavior.

Some four million years ago, several species of upright walking apes, called Australopithecines, spread across the grasslands of East Africa. By 2.4 million years ago, *Homo habilis* ("handy man") were making stone tools, marking the beginning of the Paleolithic Age (Early Stone Age). *Homo habilis* were 40–50 in (1–1.3 m) tall on average and hominins continued to grow taller until the appearance 1.9 million years ago of *Homo erectus* ("upright man"), who were about as tall as modern humans. *Homo erectus* developed leaf-shaped hand axes, the first tools made to a design, and learned how to control fire. *Homo erectus* are thought to be the first hominins to leave Africa and

move into Asia. Evolution continued until around 300,000 years ago when our own species, *Homo sapiens*, appeared in Africa. We later spread to every part of the world, replacing all of the other surviving human species.



▲ AUSTRALOPITHECUS

Walking upright helped Australopithecus stay cool and see further, and freed up their hands to carry and throw. Their short legs suggest they would not have been fast runners. This skeleton of a female, nicknamed Lucy, was discovered in Ethiopia in 1974.



▲ EARLY TOOLS

Homo habilis used broken river pebbles as tools. These stones could crack nuts and smash open animal bones to reach the healthy marrow inside. It is likely that *Homo habilis* were scavengers, feeding on animals killed by other predators, rather than hunting regularly themselves.

Homo erectus may have been hairier than humans today.

